

It takes Amazon river water at least one month to flow from the Andes to the Atlantic

Main channel

The largest channel in a river system usually bears the name of the main river, but not always. Here, above the confluence with the Rio Negro, the Amazon's main channel is known locally as the Rio Solimões.

◁ CONFLUENCE

At a confluence known as the Meeting of Waters, just downstream of the city of Manaus, the dark waters of the Rio Negro ("black river") meet the sandy-colored waters of the Rio Solimões. The waters run side by side for several miles before mixing.

Plateau

A broad plateau, rather than a sharp mountain ridge, may divide river basins. The Guiana Highlands plateau forms the northeast section of the Amazon's watershed. Rain falling on the northwest of this plateau flows into the Orinoco.

Atlantic Ocean

Shelf area

Beyond a river's delta, river sediment continues to settle, building up a shelf of material on the seabed. On the Amazon's shelf area, a newly discovered reef system thrives, even though the river's vast sediment plume cuts out most sunlight.

△ ESTUARY

The form of a river's mouth depends on many factors, including the load of sediment and the volume of water it carries. The Amazon's broad mouth contains many islands, including Marajó Island, thought to be the world's largest island created by river sediment.

◁ FLOODPLAIN

Repeated flooding distributes a river's sediment over its valley floor, where it settles in perfectly flat layers, creating a floodplain. In the rainy season, the Amazon's floodplain can be covered by up to 28 ft (9 m) of water. To cope with this, many floodplain inhabitants live in stilt houses.

Deforestation

Changes in vegetation affect the speed of water runoff into a river system and the amount of soil erosion. Deforestation in the Amazon Basin makes flood waters peak more quickly and at a higher level. It also increases soil erosion and sediment load in the river.